

Presentism Trial Classroom Run Kit

TOK Cognitive Science Activity Bank • History • 35-45 min

Category	History	Time	35-45 min
Difficulty	Extended	ID	presentism-trial

Big idea: Historical judgement involves ethical tension.

One-Minute Teacher Brief

Students explore ethical judgement and contextual understanding in history.

Student Prompt

Inspect Presentism Trial Stimulus A. Record one first claim, the evidence you used, your confidence, and what would make you revise.

Concrete Stimulus Packet

Presentism Trial Stimulus A	Student-facing stimulus 1: A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Students inspect this exact card first and commit to a claim before hearing anyone else.
Presentism Trial Stimulus B	Student-facing stimulus 2: Role cards for prosecution, defence, context witness, and judge. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Use this for comparison, a second round, or a partner challenge.
Presentism Trial Reveal / Twist	Student-facing stimulus 3: A verdict statement separating explanation from excuse. Mark what the source shows, what it omits, whose perspective appears, and what claim it can responsibly support.	Teacher reveal: connect the changed response to the big idea — Historical judgement involves ethical tension.

Actual Lesson Questions

#	Question for students	Teacher key / cue
1	After inspecting Presentism Trial Stimulus A, what is your first knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: look for a clear claim, not just a description.
2	Which exact detail from Presentism Trial Stimulus A did you use as evidence?	Teacher cue: students should name visible words, data, source features, method features, or contextual clues.
3	What did you infer beyond the evidence?	Teacher cue: this is where assumptions, framing, models, or perspective usually appear.
4	How confident are you: 50%, 60%, 70%, 80%, 90%, or 100%?	Teacher cue: confidence is data for the debrief, not a grade.
5	What missing information would most improve the knowledge claim?	Teacher cue: push for method, source, context, comparison, or definitions.
6	Should we judge the past by present standards?	Teacher cue: students should move from the classroom example to a general TOK issue.

Student Task

Use the stimulus cards to complete the observation/inference/evidence/confidence grid, then answer one TOK knowledge question connected to History.

Teacher Key / Reveal

The key move is not the “right answer”; it is the moment students see how historical judgement involves ethical tension.

- Strong response: separates observation from inference.
- Strong response: names a method, source, model, language choice, context, or perspective.
- Strong response: revises confidence when new evidence or a new criterion appears.
- Weak response: gives only opinion or says “it depends” without criteria.

Student Instructions

- Work silently for the first response so you can notice your own starting point.
- Record one knowledge claim, the evidence behind it, and your confidence level.
- After the reveal or comparison, update your claim in a different colour or column.
- Use the debrief to answer: Should we judge the past by present standards?

Setup Checklist

- Prepare a starter stimulus using: A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards.
- Print or project the student response grid before the activity begins.
- Plan a private first-response moment before any group discussion.

Example Stimuli or Materials

- A historical actor put on trial using present-day and period-specific standards.
- Role cards for prosecution, defence, context witness, and judge.
- A verdict statement separating explanation from excuse.

Resources To Use

- Resource pack: <resources/presentism-trial/index.html>
- Card deck CSV: <resources/presentism-trial/cards.csv>
- Visual prompt: <resources/presentism-trial/visual-prompt.svg>
- Printable student worksheet with observation, inference, evidence, and confidence columns.
- Teacher notes with setup checklist, sample facilitation language, misconceptions, and assessment look-fors.
- Classroom run kit with prompt cards, example stimuli, and debrief moves.
- PowerPoint deck with a student-facing sequence for running the activity.

Run Sequence

1. Put the historical case "on trial".
2. Half the class uses present-day values. Half uses values and constraints of the period.
3. The judge panel decides what each side understood and ignored.
4. Debrief the difference between explanation, justification and excuse.

Debrief Moves

- Knowledge question: Should we judge the past by present standards?
- Can understanding become excuse-making?
- What responsibilities do historians have when interpreting morally troubling evidence?

Teacher Quick Script

- Write your first judgement before we discuss it; the first answer is useful evidence.
- Separate what you noticed from what you inferred.
- What would make this knowledge claim more reliable?

Exit Ticket

- One thing I first treated as evidence was...
- My confidence changed because...
- A better knowledge question I can now ask is...